

*Haligric Research Integration Series*

# THE ARI PEOPLE OF ETHIOPIA

## A COMPLETE DEEP DIVE

*Sacred Leadership, Ancestor Veneration, Divination, and the Living Traditions of the Omo Valley's Largest People*

---

*The Babi walks through the nine territories carrying a sacred authority older than memory — chief and priest in a single body, the living link between the community and the divine. When someone dies, the intestines of the sacrificed sheep are spread and read by the specialist whose knowledge determines why the spirit withdrew its protection. The Mana blacksmith shapes iron in a lineage that carries sacred risk and sacred power in equal measure. The women who form clay into jebena pots are not making vessels — they are making the sacred container that holds the ceremony that holds the community.*

The Ari (Aari) people are the largest ethnic group in Ethiopia's Omo Valley — approximately 120,000 to 467,000 people, depending on the estimate, living in the highlands and adjacent lowlands north of Mago National Park in the South Omo Region of southwestern Ethiopia. They are Omotic-speaking agriculturalists whose territory is divided into nine independent sacred units, each with its own Babi — a hereditary leader who is simultaneously chief, priest, judge, and living embodiment of the community's relationship with the divine. Their traditional religion centered on two deities — the god Saabi and the goddess Beri — and on the active presence of ancestral spirits whose contentment or resentment directly determined the community's health, fertility, and fortune. They are a people whose sacred world is organized around the land they farm, the ancestors who farmed it before them, and the specific specialists — the Babi, the Godmi, the Mana artisan — whose knowledge maintains the relationship between the human and sacred worlds.

# Contents

|                                                               |    |
|---------------------------------------------------------------|----|
| Introduction.....                                             | 3  |
| Who the Ari Are.....                                          | 4  |
| The Sacred Landscape of Ari Territory.....                    | 5  |
| Saabi and Beri — The Traditional Deities.....                 | 6  |
| The Babi — The Divine Chief.....                              | 7  |
| The Godmi — The Ritual Specialist.....                        | 8  |
| Ancestor Veneration and the Spirit World.....                 | 9  |
| The Sacred Calendar — Lunar Months and Four Seasons.....      | 10 |
| Birth, Marriage, and Death Ceremonies.....                    | 11 |
| Intestine Divination — Reading the Body of the Sacrifice..... | 12 |
| The Mana — The Sacred Artisan Caste.....                      | 13 |
| The Sacred Crafts — Pottery, Blacksmithing, and Honey.....    | 14 |
| The Coffee Ceremony and Sacred Hospitality.....               | 15 |
| Body Art, Scarification, and Sacred Adornment.....            | 16 |
| Legacy and the Pressures of Change.....                       | 17 |
| Controversies.....                                            | 18 |
| The Haligric Lens.....                                        | 19 |

## Introduction

### The Largest People of the Omo Valley

The Omo Valley of southwestern Ethiopia is one of the most extraordinary concentrations of cultural and ethnic diversity on earth — a region where dozens of distinct peoples, speaking dozens of distinct languages, maintaining distinct sacred traditions, sacred leadership structures, and sacred cosmologies, live within proximity of one another in a landscape that has sustained human habitation continuously for hundreds of thousands of years. The Omo Valley is where some of the oldest *Homo sapiens* fossils have been found. It is where the Omo River runs south to Lake Turkana, creating a corridor of fertile land in an otherwise challenging landscape. And it is home to the Ari people — the largest of all the Omo Valley peoples, with the largest territory, the most fertile land, and the most developed agricultural system in the region.

The Ari are Omotic speakers — members of one of the most ancient and linguistically distinctive language families in Africa, the Omotic branch of the Afro-Asiatic family, whose speakers have inhabited southwestern Ethiopia for thousands of years. The Ari language has nine dialects, reflecting the nine independent territorial subdivisions into which Ari land has been organized since before recorded history. Until the late 19th century, the Ari lived under independent chiefdoms. In the 1880s and 1890s, the forces of Emperor Menelik II incorporated the South Omo region into the expanding Ethiopian empire, a conquest that brought Orthodox Christian priests alongside military forces — and with them, the first systematic pressure on the Ari's traditional sacred life.

The Ari's traditional sacred world has survived this pressure in layers. Some Ari became Orthodox Christians — though the association of that church with colonial conquest gave it a stigma that limited its reach. Far more became Protestants through the intensive missionary work of SIM (Serving in Mission) beginning in the 1950s and of the Kale Hiywot Church that grew from SIM's ministry. Today the majority of Ari identify as Protestant Christians. But traditional religion — the veneration of the ancestors, the authority of the Babi and Godmi, the sacrifice and the divination and the sacred relationship with the land — has never fully disappeared. It continues, in varying degrees, alongside and beneath the Christian overlay, in the same way that sacred traditions have always survived in communities that have been converted by force or economic pressure rather than genuine spiritual transformation.

## Who the Ari Are

### Language, Territory, and Social Structure

The Ari (also written Aari) speak the Aari language, classified in the South Omotic branch of the Afro-Asiatic language family. The language has nine dialects corresponding to the nine territorial subdivisions of Ari land. With approximately 120,000 to 467,000 speakers (estimates vary significantly across different censuses and studies), Aari is one of the more vital indigenous languages of southern Ethiopia, though like all minority languages in the region it faces pressure from Amharic — Ethiopia's national language — and from the educational system. The Ari are also typically multilingual, with most adults speaking Amharic in addition to Aari, and many speaking neighboring tribal languages as well.

The Ari inhabit a landscape that is unusually fertile by Omo Valley standards — highland territory north of Mago National Park, receiving substantial rainfall, allowing the cultivation of a remarkable variety of crops. This agricultural abundance distinguishes the Ari from many of their Omo Valley neighbors, most of whom are pastoral or semi-pastoral. The Ari are primarily farmers. Their crops include cereals (wheat, barley, sorghum, maize, teff, millet), pulses (broad beans, peas), root crops (taro, enset — the false banana, yam, cassava, potato), vegetables, fruits, and two major cash crops: coffee and cardamom. Their enset cultivation is particularly significant — enset is a staple in highland southwestern Ethiopia, providing a fermented food staple that can sustain communities through drought years when grain crops fail. The Ari also maintain livestock (cattle, sheep, goats, chickens, donkeys, mules) and have a strong tradition of apiculture — beekeeping and the production of honey and honey beer (tej).

### Social Structure

Ari society is organized around clans, each tracing its origin to a specific natural feature — a river, a mountain, a tree, a specific animal. These clan origin stories are not merely genealogical — they are sacred geography: each clan carries a specific relationship with a specific element of the natural world, and the ceremonies, prohibitions, and obligations of each clan reflect that relationship. The family is the basic social unit, organized within the clan. Elders hold significant decision-making authority. Disputes are mediated through a council of elders with the Babi as the ultimate authority in each territorial unit.

The social hierarchy within each territorial unit follows a specific structure. At the apex is the Babi — the hereditary political, economic, and religious leader. Below the Babi is the Godmi — the ritual specialist who performs the sacrifices and ceremonies the Babi authorizes but does not execute. Below the Godmi are the Zis (village leaders), the Tsoiki (information agents and community communicators), and the Keisi (ordinary commoners). The Mana — the artisan caste of blacksmiths, tanners, potters, basket weavers, and wood carvers — occupy a specific social position that is simultaneously lower in ordinary status and higher in sacred significance. A separate section addresses this important distinction.

## The Sacred Landscape of Ari Territory

### Nine Territories, Nine Sacred Units, One People

The most fundamental organizing principle of the Ari sacred world is the ninefold division of their territory. Ari land is divided into nine independent territorial subdivisions, each with its own Babi, its own Godmi, its own ceremonial calendar and sacred sites. The number nine appears throughout Ari sacred culture in ways that are not coincidental — nine territories, nine dialects, a structure that recurs across the sacred geography of the people. This ninefold structure reflects an ancient understanding of sacred governance: the territory is not merely administrative but sacred, each unit a complete sacred community unto itself while remaining part of the larger Ari people.

The landscape itself carries sacred meaning. Mountains, rivers, and specific trees function as sacred markers — clan origins, sacred boundaries, and ceremonial sites are embedded in specific features of the Ari landscape. The northern border of Mago National Park is not merely a modern administrative boundary to the Ari — it is the southern edge of their sacred geography, marking the territory where the relationship between the Ari community and the land transitions from cultivated to wild. The park itself, in its pre-colonial form, was part of a broader sacred landscape that the Ari navigated with specific protocols of respect, offering, and avoidance.

Sacred sites within Ari territory include specific trees under which ceremonies are performed, specific rocks and hills associated with ancestor spirits, specific springs and water sources that require offerings, and the ceremonial centers within each territorial unit where the Babi and Godmi perform the community's most important sacred work. These sites are not formally marked or institutionalized — their sacred character is maintained through community knowledge, through the specific protocols of approach and behavior that each generation transmits to the next, and through the ceremonies that keep the sacred relationship active.

## Saabi and Beri — The Traditional Deities

### The God and the Goddess of the Ari Sacred World

The traditional theology of the Ari centered on two divine beings: Saabi, a male deity, and Beri, a female deity. These two divine principles organized the Ari's understanding of the sacred world and their relationship to it. While the specific mythology and theology of Saabi and Beri is not extensively documented in the available scholarly literature — reflecting both the oral nature of the tradition and the relatively limited academic attention that Ari religious life has received compared to neighboring groups — the existence of a male-female divine dyad at the center of the tradition is consistent with broader Omotic and southern Ethiopian religious patterns.

#### Saabi

Saabi is the male principle of the Ari divine world. His specific attributes and the mythology surrounding him have not been fully documented in the accessible literature, but the structural role of a male creator or sky deity in Omotic traditions generally involves the ordering of the cosmos, the governance of the agricultural year, and the maintenance of the sacred law that the Babi embodies in human form. The Babi's authority as hereditary chief-priest may be understood as the human expression of Saabi's divine authority — the chief's body carrying the sacred mandate of the god whose name his community carries.

#### Beri

Beri is the female principle — the goddess whose domain encompasses fertility, the earth's productive capacity, and the wellbeing of women and children. The centrality of a female divine principle in a highland Ethiopian agricultural society is structurally consistent with the importance of earth fertility in the community's survival. The Ari women's role as the primary potters — makers of the sacred vessels that hold the community's ceremonies — and as the cultivators of the enset plant (whose gender in Ari cultural imagination connects it to the feminine) reflects this feminine sacred dimension in practical daily life. Beri's presence in the tradition suggests an understanding that the earth's generosity is not given but cultivated, not automatic but requiring specific relationship and specific ceremony to maintain.

### Religious Layering

The traditional religion of Saabi and Beri has been substantially overlaid by Christianity through two centuries of missionary and imperial pressure. The Joshua Project, a Christian missionary tracking organization, notes that "they used to worship two gods, the god Saabi and the goddess Beri" — framing the tradition in the past tense. The reality is more complex: traditional religion coexists with Christian practice in many Ari communities, with ancestor veneration, divination, and sacrificial ceremonies continuing alongside church attendance. This layering is characteristic of communities that have experienced forced or incentivized conversion — the new religion occupies the public institutional space while the older tradition maintains its hold on the immediate practical and spiritual needs the new religion does not fully address.

## The Babi — The Divine Chief

### The Living Intersection of Political, Economic, and Religious Authority

The Babi is one of the most distinctive features of the Ari sacred world — a figure who combines in a single hereditary office the functions that most other societies distribute among multiple specialists: chief, priest, judge, and sacred intermediary. The Babi is not merely a political leader who also performs religious functions, nor a priest who also has political authority. The Babi is, in the Ari understanding, the living embodiment of the community's relationship with the divine — the person in whose body the authority of Saabi and the welfare of the territory are simultaneously held.

The Babi's authority is hereditary — it passes within a specific family lineage, from father to son or through the designated heir within the ruling family. This hereditary character is not arbitrary nepotism in the Ari understanding — it reflects the belief that the sacred authority embodied in the Babi is transmitted through blood, that specific families carry specific relationships with the divine that cannot simply be elected or appointed but must be born into. The baabi (plural) of each of the nine territorial units are thus simultaneously nine political leaders and nine sacred centers of their respective communities.

### The Babi's Sacred Functions

The Babi presides over the community's major ceremonies — the seasonal agricultural rituals, the ceremonies marking births, marriages, and deaths, the sacrificial ceremonies that maintain right relationship with the ancestor spirits, and the community assemblies where disputes are judged. He authorizes the sacrifices that the Godmi performs. He is the primary intercessor between the community and the divine, the person whose specific relationship with Saabi gives his prayers and pronouncements their sacred efficacy. He is also the economic authority of his territorial unit — mediating access to land, adjudicating resource disputes, and governing the relationships between the Ari community and neighboring peoples.

The combination of these functions in a single person means that the Babi's health, moral character, and sacred standing directly affect the wellbeing of the entire community. A Babi who has violated sacred law, who has broken the community's relationship with the ancestors, or who carries spiritual contamination is understood to transmit those consequences to the land and people under his authority. This is why the selection and ongoing maintenance of the Babi's sacred standing is a matter of community survival, not merely political preference.

## The Godmi — The Ritual Specialist

### The Babi's Sacred Arm — The Executor of Ceremony

The Godmi is the Babi's ritual specialist — the person who possesses the specific technical knowledge of ceremony, sacrifice, and divination that the Babi authorizes but does not personally execute. The Godmi is the practical sacred specialist of the Ari community, the person who knows how a sacrifice must be performed, how the intestines must be read, what specific plants and materials are required for specific ceremonies, and how the ancestors must be addressed to achieve specific ends.

The Godmi's position in the Ari social structure sits just below the Babi in formal hierarchy but carries its own distinct form of sacred authority. Where the Babi's authority derives from hereditary sacred status, the Godmi's authority derives from specific ritual knowledge — the accumulated learning of ceremony, divination, and sacred protocol that is transmitted within the Godmi's lineage and through direct training and apprenticeship. The Godmi is the keeper of the community's ceremonial memory, the person who knows what was done before and why, and whose knowledge ensures that the ceremonies performed today maintain their efficacy through the continuity of correct practice.

The relationship between the Babi and the Godmi is the fundamental sacred dyad of the Ari community. Neither can function fully without the other. The Babi provides the authority and the community mandate; the Godmi provides the technical knowledge and the execution. Together they form the complete sacred leadership of each territorial unit — the public face of sacred authority (the Babi) and the operational heart of sacred practice (the Godmi).



## Ancestor Veneration and the Spirit World

### The Dead as Active Participants in Community Life

The most practically significant dimension of the Ari sacred world is the relationship with the ancestors — the community of the dead whose continued presence in the lives of their descendants is active, consequential, and demanding. Illness, infertility, failed crops, difficult births, and unexplained deaths are not, in the Ari understanding, random events or the workings of impersonal fate. They are consequences. They are the expression of a specific ancestral spirit's resentment — a deceased relative whose needs have not been met, whose memory has not been properly honored, or whose sacred relationship with the living community has been disrupted by the community's failure to perform the required ceremonies and maintain the required protocols of respect.

This understanding places the living community in an ongoing relationship of obligation toward the dead. The ancestors are not passive recipients of memorial — they are active participants in the community's life, with specific needs, specific preferences, and specific responses to how they are treated. To honor them correctly is to secure their protection and their blessing. To neglect them is to invite their resentment, which manifests as the specific disruptions and afflictions that the Godmi is called upon to diagnose and address.

### The Sacrifice of Appeasement

The primary mechanism for addressing ancestral resentment is sacrificial appeasement — the offering of a sheep (the standard sacrifice in Ari tradition) to the aggrieved ancestor, accompanied by the specific prayers and ceremonies that acknowledge the community's failure and request renewed protection. The sacrifice is not merely symbolic. It is the specific material gift that restores the relationship of gift-and-counter-gift between the living and the dead. The ancestor receives the sacrifice and, having been honored, withdraws their resentment. The illness lifts. The fertility returns. The crops improve. The sacred economy of the Ari world operates through this mechanism of offering and response across the boundary between life and death.

### Clan Origin Legends and Sacred Nature Relationships

Alongside the relationship with individual ancestors, the Ari maintain a broader sacred cosmology organized around clan origin legends — stories that trace each clan's descent from a specific natural feature: a river, a mountain, a particular tree, a specific animal. These origin stories are not merely genealogical myths. They are sacred geography — each clan carries a specific relationship with a specific element of the natural world, and that relationship organizes the clan's prohibitions (what its members may not eat or touch), its ceremonial obligations (what specific ceremonies must be performed at specific natural sites), and its understanding of its own nature and purpose within the larger Ari community.

## The Sacred Calendar — Lunar Months and Four Seasons

### Time as Sacred Structure

The Ari organize their year around a lunar calendar — twelve named months, each beginning on the day of the new moon, and four seasons that reflect the highland agricultural cycle. This is not merely a practical system for tracking time. It is a sacred framework that organizes the community's relationship with the natural world and with the ceremonies that maintain that relationship. The lunar calendar ties the community's sacred life directly to the movements of the moon — each new moon marks a sacred threshold, a moment of beginning that carries its own ceremonial significance.

The four seasons of the Ari calendar correspond to the agricultural reality of their highland landscape: the long rains season (the primary agricultural period), the short dry season, the short rains season, and the long dry season. Each transition between seasons carries ceremonial weight — the beginning of the planting season requires specific ceremonies to secure the land's fertility and the ancestors' blessing; the harvest requires specific ceremonies of thanksgiving and offering; the dry seasons carry their own sacred protocols of water conservation and livestock management.

The Ari's twelve-month lunar calendar is one of the specific features that distinguishes their sacred temporal world from both the Ethiopian Orthodox calendar (which follows the Julian calendar in its Ge'ez form) and the Islamic Hijri calendar — reflecting the continuity of a pre-Christian, pre-Islamic timekeeping tradition rooted in the specific agricultural rhythms of their highland landscape.

# Birth, Marriage, and Death Ceremonies

## The Life-Cycle Rituals of the Ari

### Birth

The birth of a child in Ari tradition is a ceremonially significant event that requires specific sacred acknowledgment at multiple stages. Pregnancy is accompanied by specific prohibitions and protections designed to maintain the wellbeing of both mother and child. The period immediately after birth — when both mother and child are in a liminal state, neither fully in the ordinary social world nor fully secure in the sacred world — is governed by specific protocols of seclusion, feeding, and ceremony. The naming of the child is a sacred act that brings the child fully into the community and establishes its identity within the clan structure. The ceremony at which the child is named is accompanied by prayer, the acknowledgment of the ancestral spirits who have permitted the child's entry into the community, and the specific gifts and celebratory practices that mark a new life's arrival.

### Marriage

Marriage in Ari tradition is governed by the payment of bridewealth (called *dauri*) — a payment from the groom's family to the bride's family that establishes the formal sacred and social relationship between the two families. The amount and composition of the *dauri* is negotiated between families and reflects the social standing of both parties, the qualities of the bride, and the strength of the alliance being formed. Marriage ceremonies are accompanied by music, dance, feasting, and ceremony — events that engage the entire community and assert publicly the new relationships being formed. Traditional Ari practice permitted polygamy — a man could marry as many women as he could support with appropriate bridewealth and household provision. Under Christian influence this practice has substantially declined, and most Ari men today have one wife.

### Death

Death is the most ceremonially complex moment in the Ari sacred calendar. When a person dies, the community enters a period of mourning that involves specific wailing and lamentation ceremonies, the gathering of the clan, and the preparation of the body for burial. Most significantly — a sheep is slaughtered and its intestines are read by the diviner to determine the cause of death. This specific ritual, described in more detail in the following section, is the Ari's primary mechanism for understanding the sacred cause behind a physical event. The oldest son of the oldest generation typically performs or oversees the ritual responsibilities for the whole clan at times of death, maintaining the genealogical continuity of the clan's sacred relationship with its ancestors through the eldest male line.

## Intestine Divination — Reading the Body of the Sacrifice

### Haruspicy — The Sacred Technology of Diagnosis

Among the most distinctive and most specific sacred practices of the Ari is haruspicy — the reading of the intestines of a sacrificed sheep to determine sacred causes and divine answers to specific community questions. This practice, sometimes called haruspicy after the Roman term for the same practice, is one of the oldest documented forms of divination in human history — attested in Mesopotamia from at least the 3rd millennium BCE, present in ancient Etruscan and Roman religion, and found across a remarkable geographic range of cultures as an independent invention or ancient cultural transmission.

In the Ari context, intestine divination is specifically associated with death and with illness. When a person dies, a sheep is slaughtered and its intestines are spread and examined by the Godmi or the designated ritual specialist. The specific patterns of the intestines — their color, their shape, the presence or absence of specific features, the relationship between different sections — are read to determine the sacred cause of the death. Was the death caused by the resentment of a specific ancestor? Which ancestor? What did that ancestor require that was not provided? What must now be done to restore the relationship and prevent further deaths?

### The Sacred Logic of Divination

The Ari practice of intestine divination reflects a specific and coherent understanding of how sacred knowledge becomes accessible to the living. The ordinary world does not directly reveal the movements of the ancestral and divine forces that shape it. The diviner requires a medium — a liminal object that stands at the boundary between the living and the sacred, that carries within its physical form the traces of the invisible forces at work. The intestines of a freshly sacrificed animal — an animal whose life has just been offered to the sacred world — are understood as a surface on which those forces have inscribed their answer. The diviner's skill is the ability to read that inscription accurately.

This understanding is not unique to the Ari — haruspicy reflects a widespread human intuition that the inner structures of living bodies carry information about the sacred forces that shape ordinary life. The Ari version is specifically focused on death and illness diagnosis, using the sacrifice both as the offering to the relevant ancestor and as the divination medium through which that ancestor's answer is received.

## The Mana — The Sacred Artisan Caste

### The Paradox of Lowly Status and Sacred Power

One of the most distinctive and most widely documented features of the Ari social world is the Mana — the hereditary artisan caste whose members include the community's blacksmiths, tanners, potters, basket weavers, and wood carvers. The Mana occupy a position in Ari society that is deeply paradoxical: they hold lower ordinary social status than the farming majority, are subject to specific social restrictions and stigmas, and in some contexts are considered ritually impure — yet their practical knowledge is essential to the community's material life, and their work carries a sacred significance that no other social category matches.

This paradox — the socially marginal artisan as sacred specialist — is not unique to the Ari. It appears across a remarkable range of cultures worldwide: the blacksmith who is feared and essential, the potter whose knowledge of transformation (clay into vessel, raw material into sacred object) mirrors the divine creative act, the tanner who works with the dead bodies of animals and carries their sacred power. The Ari Mana reflect this universal pattern in specifically Ethiopian Omotic form.

### The Blacksmith

The Ari blacksmith (a male role within the Mana) works iron — the transformative craft of converting raw metal into tools, weapons, and sacred objects. The blacksmith's forge is a sacred space — fire, metal, and the blacksmith's knowledge combine to produce transformation that is understood as a creative act parallel to the divine. The products of the blacksmith's work — agricultural tools, spear points, ritual objects — carry within them the sacred power of the transformation that produced them. The blacksmith is simultaneously feared (his knowledge is dangerous, his forge carries sacred fire) and essential (without his tools, the agricultural life of the community cannot function).

### The Potter

The Ari potter (a female role within the Mana) creates the clay vessels — including the jebena coffee pots — that are central to Ari sacred and social life. The potter's knowledge of clay transformation (raw earth shaped and fired into a vessel capable of holding liquid, of being offered in ceremony, of serving as the medium through which hospitality and sacred relationship are enacted) is understood as a sacred craft. Each Ari woman potter has her own style of decoration — her personal visual language inscribed in the painted patterns of her work, making her vessels simultaneously functional objects and expressions of individual sacred identity. The social restriction on the potter's ordinary status exists in tension with the sacred significance of the objects her knowledge produces.

## The Sacred Crafts — Pottery, Blacksmithing, and Honey

### Material Knowledge as Sacred Practice

Beyond the Mana's specifically sacred artisan work, the Ari maintain a broader tradition of craft knowledge that carries sacred dimensions. Three crafts deserve specific attention: pottery, blacksmithing (addressed in the Mana section), and apiculture — the keeping of bees and the production of honey and honey beer.

### Pottery and the Jebena

The clay pot called the jebena — the traditional Ethiopian coffee brewing vessel — is one of the most sacred objects in Ari daily life. Made by women potters using locally sourced clay, shaped by hand, decorated with personal patterns using charcoal, ash, earth, and other natural materials, and fired in open fires, the jebena is simultaneously a practical brewing vessel and a sacred object whose quality and care reflect the maker's knowledge and the sacred significance of the ceremony it enables. The jebena is used in the Ari coffee ceremony — a deeply significant social and sacred event described in the following section. Its creation by women of the Mana lineage who have specific inherited knowledge of clay-working connects the practical object to the larger sacred world of craft-as-ceremony.

### Honey and Tej

The Ari are active beekeepers — apiculture has been practiced in their highland territory for generations, and the production of honey and of tej (honey beer) occupies a specific sacred role in Ari ceremonial life. Honey is the sweetest naturally occurring substance in the highland Ethiopian landscape, and its association with abundance, goodness, and sacred blessing is deep and consistent. Tej — fermented honey mead — is the ceremonial drink of the Ari, served at major life-cycle ceremonies, offered at sacred occasions, and shared at community gatherings as the physical expression of hospitality and goodwill. The production of tej from the community's own honey connects the ceremonial drink directly to the land, to the bees who work it, and to the ancestors whose blessing makes the land productive.

# The Coffee Ceremony and Sacred Hospitality

## Bunna — The Sacred Ceremony of Welcome

Coffee originated in Ethiopia — specifically in the Kaffa region adjacent to the Ari territory, and the Ari themselves grow coffee as one of their primary cash crops. The coffee ceremony (bunna in Amharic) is one of the most important sacred and social practices in all of Ethiopian culture, and the Ari version of this ceremony reflects the specific character of their sacred hospitality tradition.

The Ari coffee ceremony is performed by women, using the clay jebena pot made by the community's potters, in the context of welcoming guests, marking significant social occasions, and maintaining the ongoing relationships of community solidarity that are the Ari's primary social fabric. To be invited to the coffee ceremony is to be brought into the innermost circle of hospitality — the domestic sacred space of the host household.

## The Ceremony — Step by Step

**Step 1 — The Space:** The ceremony is performed in a specific domestic space, prepared with fresh grass spread on the floor — a traditional Ethiopian mark of sacred hospitality that transforms the ordinary floor into a liminal ceremonial surface. Incense is burned — typically frankincense — which simultaneously purifies the space, marks the ceremony as sacred, and creates the specific sensory environment that signals the transition from ordinary domestic life to sacred communal time.

**Step 2 — The Roasting:** Green coffee beans are roasted over an open flame in a flat pan, stirred constantly until they are fragrant and dark. The roasting is performed by the woman of the household, who is simultaneously the priest of this ceremony. As the beans roast, their fragrance fills the space and reaches every person present — sharing the aroma of the roasting beans is itself a sacred gesture, the hostess moving the roasting pan around the circle of guests so each person can draw the fragrance toward themselves with both hands. This gesture of sharing the sacred scent is an act of blessing — the hostess is distributing sacred power before the ceremony has formally begun.

**Step 3 — The Grinding:** The roasted beans are ground in the wooden mortar (mukecha) using the pestle (zenezena). The grinding is manual, rhythmic, and communal — its sound is the sound of the ceremony in progress. The ground coffee is then added to the jebena filled with water and placed on the fire.

**Step 4 — The Three Rounds:** Ethiopian coffee ceremony traditionally involves three rounds of coffee, each with its own name and sacred significance. The first round (Abol) is the strongest — the first pour from the freshly brewed jebena. The second round (Tona) is slightly weaker. The third round (Bereka — meaning blessing) is the lightest but carries the most sacred significance: to drink the third cup is to receive the blessing of the ceremony. Each round is served in small ceramic cups (sini) without handles. Sugar or, in traditional contexts, salt or butter may be added.

**Step 5 — The Community:** Between rounds, the ceremony creates space for conversation, for the sharing of news and community concerns, for the maintenance of social bonds. The coffee ceremony is explicitly a community-building ceremony — its sacred function is not only to honor the sacred in the natural world but to weave the human community more tightly together through the shared sacred act of drinking.

## Body Art, Scarification, and Sacred Adornment

### The Body as Sacred Text

The Ari maintain specific traditions of body adornment that carry sacred significance. Women wear distinctive clothing — traditionally skirts made from the leaves of the enset plant (the false banana), reflecting the intimate connection between the Ari's primary crop and their most intimate material culture. In more rural communities, women still wear these traditional garments alongside colorful bead necklaces, bracelets, and other adornments that carry specific information about social status, marital situation, and community identity.

Ari men wear distinctive ceremonial hats adorned with colorful beads during ceremonies — a specific sacred adornment that marks the wearer as participating in the ceremonial life of the community and as holding a specific social identity within it. The bead-decorated hat is not everyday clothing — it is ceremonial dress, its wearing a statement of participation in the sacred life of the community.

Scarification was historically practiced among the Ari, though this tradition has substantially declined under the combined pressure of Christian missionary influence, access to medical care, and modernization. Where practiced, scarification served as a permanent marking of identity — clan membership, life-stage transitions, sacred relationships — inscribed directly onto the body as a text that could be read by anyone with the cultural knowledge to interpret it. The body so marked was simultaneously a personal body and a community document, its surface carrying the sacred history of the individual's relationships and identities.

The Ari practice of body painting — using natural materials including charcoal, ash, earth, and plant dyes — continues in ceremonial contexts. Body painting for dance, ceremony, and community gathering is a living tradition, the painted body entering the ceremonial space as a visually transformed being whose painted surface marks their participation in the ceremony's sacred dimension.



## Legacy and the Pressures of Change

### The Most Rapidly Adapting Community in the Omo Valley

The Ari are often described by scholars and travelers as the most rapidly adapting community in the Omo Valley — a characterization that reflects both their relative prosperity (greater agricultural wealth gives them more resources to engage with the modern economy) and the intensity of the religious and educational pressure they have experienced. The SIM missionary presence beginning in the 1950s was particularly effective among the Ari, producing not only converts but — as the Joshua Project notes — indigenous missionaries who themselves went out to evangelize neighboring tribes. This level of religious engagement reflects the Ari's general cultural vitality and their willingness to engage new systems on their own terms.

Modernization has brought roads, schools, and healthcare to the Ari highlands — developments that have significantly improved material wellbeing while simultaneously accelerating cultural change. The weekly markets at Jinka and Barka, where the Ari trade with neighboring peoples including the Mursi (with whom they have had periodic conflicts), have become hubs of cultural exchange and economic integration that further weave the Ari into the broader Ethiopian and regional economy.

### What Has Been Lost and What Persists

The worship of Saabi and Beri as explicit divine centers of the tradition has largely given way to Christian theological frameworks. Polygamy has substantially declined. Scarification is much rarer than it was a generation ago. The specific ceremonial protocols that governed the Babi's authority and the Godmi's ritual work have been disrupted by the displacement of traditional sacred authority by church structures. The Mana artisan caste's stigmatized status has been partially challenged by Christian teachings of human equality, though caste identity persists in practice if not in formal ideology.

What persists: the lunar calendar continues to organize the agricultural year. Ancestor veneration continues, sometimes alongside Christian prayer — the two frameworks addressing different spiritual needs without necessarily canceling each other. The divination of intestines at death continues in rural communities where the Godmi tradition remains alive. The coffee ceremony is as vital as ever, if not more so — it has absorbed into itself the sacred hospitality function that once operated through multiple ceremonial channels. The pottery tradition continues, the Mana women's knowledge of clay transformation transmitting across generations. The honey and tej tradition persists. The community ceremonies of birth, marriage, and death continue to incorporate traditional elements alongside Christian liturgy.

## Controversies

### Conversion, Caste, and the Question of What Survives

#### The Mission History

The SIM mission's work among the Ari from the 1950s onward is a significant and contested history. The rapid conversion of large numbers of Ari to evangelical Protestantism represents one of the most effective missionary campaigns in Ethiopian history. From inside the missionary framework, this is understood as spiritual liberation — the Ari freed from "traditional bondage" and brought into the Christian community. From outside that framework, the same history can be understood as the systematic dismantling of a viable, coherent, community-sustaining sacred system under conditions where the power differential between the missionary institution (backed by international organization, medical services, and educational resources) and the indigenous community made truly free choice impossible. Both perspectives contain truth. What is certain is that the change happened rapidly, with significant consequences for the Ari's traditional sacred life.

#### The Mana Caste Question

The existence of a hereditary artisan caste with lower social status — the Mana — raises the same ethical questions that caste systems raise wherever they exist: the tension between the community functions caste performs (preserving specialized knowledge, organizing the division of labor) and the injustice of inherited social hierarchy that limits individual possibility based on birth. The Mana tradition predates Christianity in the Ari world and has partially persisted despite Christian teaching of equality, reflecting the deep structural embeddedness of caste in Ari social organization. The ongoing negotiation between the traditional caste structure and the equalizing impulse of the Christian tradition is one of the defining tensions of contemporary Ari social life.

#### The Blue Eyes Question

The Ari have attracted international attention in recent years because of the documented presence of individuals with naturally blue eyes — a rare genetic trait among African populations. Media coverage has sometimes reduced the Ari to this single genetic curiosity, stripping away the depth and complexity of their sacred tradition in favor of a visually striking anomaly. The blue-eyed individuals are a small subset of the Ari population. Their eyes do not define the tradition. A full account of the Ari sacred world requires moving past the spectacle to the substance of what this community has built and maintained over generations.

## The Haligric Lens

### What the Ari Sacred World Offers the Haligric Practitioner

The Ari tradition offers the Haligricity framework three specific gifts: the most clearly articulated example of the sacred leader as community body (the Babi), a specific and coherent technology of ancestor relationship maintenance, and a living demonstration of craft knowledge as sacred practice.

### The Babi and the Embodied Sacred Authority

The Babi is one of the clearest available examples of what it looks like when the political, the sacred, and the economic are understood as a single domain of authority rather than separate spheres. The Babi's body carries the community's relationship with the divine — his wellbeing is the community's wellbeing, his sacred standing is the community's sacred standing. This is not a metaphor. It is a practical understanding that the health of the sacred world and the health of the community that depends on it are inseparable, and that the person who mediates between them must maintain that mediation through the total quality of their life, not merely through the performance of ceremonies. The Haligric understanding of sacred leadership as embodied practice, as total-life commitment rather than institutional role, finds in the Babi one of its clearest historical expressions.

### The Ancestor Relationship as Active Sacred Economy

The Ari understanding that ancestor spirits are active participants in community life whose contentment or resentment directly shapes the community's health and fortune is one of the most practical available models of the ancestor relationship. It is not sentimental — it is economic. The ancestors gave the living the land, the knowledge, and the sacred relationships that sustain the community. The living owe the ancestors specific acknowledgment, specific offerings, and specific ceremonies. When those obligations are met, the relationship functions and the community thrives. When they are not, the ancestors withdraw their protection and the community suffers. The Haligric tradition's understanding of ancestor relationship as mutual obligation — as a specific economy of gift and counter-gift that crosses the boundary between life and death — finds in the Ari tradition one of its clearest African highland expressions.

### Craft as Sacred Knowledge Transmission

The Mana's sacred artisan knowledge — the blacksmith's iron transformation, the potter's clay transformation, the basket weaver's natural material transformation — reflects the Haligric understanding that specific embodied technical knowledge carries sacred dimensions that abstract spiritual teaching cannot replace. The knowledge of how to form clay into a sacred vessel is not simply a technical skill. It is a transmission of understanding about the relationship between raw material, human intention, fire, and sacred use that produces an object capable of holding ceremony. The fact that this knowledge is transmitted through a specific family lineage — and that the social stigma attached to the Mana reflects a community's ambivalence about sacred power in general — is itself a lesson about how communities relate to the sacred specialists in their midst.

Grand Rising. The Babi walks through his territory carrying the community's sacred mandate in his hereditary body. The Godmi spreads the intestines of the sacrifice and reads what the ancestor has written there. The Mana woman shapes the clay that will become the

jebena that will hold the coffee ceremony that will hold the community. The lunar calendar turns through its twelve months and the land responds to the ceremonies that the Ari have been performing on it for as long as memory reaches. This is what a sacred tradition looks like when it is organized around a specific land, a specific lineage, and a specific understanding of what the living owe to the dead and what the dead continue to give. Grand Rising.